

RailCore Transit Solutions

IDP Leadership Playbook

Standard Sample for Leader Track

A practical guide for sponsoring, communicating, and reinforcing Individual Development Planning across teams.

Stronger Teams. Safer Tracks. Better Journeys.

Audience	Senior leaders, HR leaders, department heads, business unit leaders
Use	Standard benchmark sample for regional IDP adoption planning
Status	Completed sample / model output

How to Use This Standard Sample

This playbook is a completed benchmark version that shows what strong leadership alignment can look like after the Leader Track workshop. Regions may adapt examples, barriers, and follow-up rhythms to their local context, but the core expectations should remain consistent across RailCore.

Standard core + regional flexibility

Use this sample as the standard reference. Regional teams can localize their talent challenges, examples, communication channels, and support resources without changing the core IDP purpose, roles, quality standards, or minimum follow-up expectations.

Core Principles

- IDPs are a leadership tool, not only an HR form.
- Employees own their development direction; managers coach the conversation; leaders reinforce the system.
- Completion is important, but quality and follow-up determine whether IDPs create value.
- Leaders use IDP data to ask better questions, remove barriers, and support teams — not to punish people.

1. Standard Leadership Message

Use or adapt the message below when introducing IDPs to managers and employees.

Sample message

At RailCore, our ability to deliver safe, reliable, and future-ready transit depends on the growth of our people. Individual Development Plans are not being introduced as another form to complete. They are a practical way to make development conversations more focused, visible, and actionable. Each employee should have a clear development goal, practical actions connected to their role or career direction, and regular follow-up with their manager. Leaders will support this process by setting expectations, reviewing progress, removing barriers, and helping managers turn IDPs into meaningful development conversations.

Message guidance

Message Element	Standard Guidance	Example Language
Acknowledge	Recognize workload and change fatigue.	We understand teams are busy and development planning can feel like one more process.
Reframe	Position IDPs as a growth and readiness tool.	The goal is to make development more intentional, not to create paperwork.
Clarify	State expectations for employees and managers.	Every employee should have one meaningful IDP conversation and practical next steps.
Support	Explain how leaders will help.	We will provide examples, tools, review rhythms, and support for barriers.

2. Why IDPs Matter at RailCore

IDPs support RailCore's talent strategy by creating a structured process for employee growth, role readiness, and capability building. The goal is not simply to increase completion rates. The goal is to make development visible, practical, and connected to business needs.

Talent Need	Why It Matters	How IDPs Help
Retention and engagement	Employees are more likely to stay when they see a future and feel supported.	IDPs create intentional conversations about growth, goals, and support.
Skill and capability gaps	Rail operations, safety, technology, and customer needs continue to change.	IDPs identify development needs and connect them to practical learning actions.
Succession readiness	Critical roles require stronger internal pipelines and readiness planning.	IDPs make future interests, strengths, and readiness gaps more visible.
Manager consistency	Development quality can vary across teams and regions.	IDPs provide a shared process and common quality standards.
Internal mobility	Talent can be underused when career interests are not visible.	IDPs surface career direction and development opportunities across teams.

3. Roles and Responsibilities

Successful IDP adoption requires clear ownership. No single group owns the entire process.

Role	Primary Responsibility	What Good Looks Like
Leaders	Sponsor, communicate, reinforce, and remove barriers.	Leaders ask about quality, follow-up, barriers, and support needs during regular business and talent reviews.
Managers	Coach the IDP conversation and support practical development actions.	Managers hold meaningful conversations, help refine goals, and schedule follow-up checkpoints.
Employees	Reflect, propose goals, take action, and update progress.	Employees come prepared, own their actions, and ask for support when needed.
HR / L&D	Provide process, tools, examples, enablement, and reporting support.	HR/L&D equips leaders and managers with templates, job aids, data, and coaching resources.

4. Manager Expectations

Managers are the key link between IDP intent and employee experience. Leaders should reinforce the following expectations consistently.

Expectation	Standard	Leader Reinforcement Question
Prepare	Review employee role expectations, strengths, and possible development areas before the IDP conversation.	What support do managers need to prepare for IDP conversations?
Hold a meaningful conversation	Use open-ended questions and listen before giving advice.	Are managers creating enough time for useful development conversations?
Improve goal quality	Help employees turn vague goals into specific, realistic, role-connected goals.	Are IDP goals specific enough to guide action?
Connect development to work	Use on-the-job learning, stretch tasks, shadowing, mentoring, cross-training, or project exposure.	Are development actions practical in the daily work environment?
Follow up	Schedule regular progress check-ins and update the plan as needed.	What follow-up rhythm is each manager using?

5. Employee Expectations

Employees should understand that an IDP is not something done to them. It is a development plan they actively shape and own.

Expectation	Employee Action	Support Needed
Reflect	Consider career interests, strengths, current role needs, and skill gaps.	Reflection prompts and example goals.
Bring ideas	Come to the conversation with at least one development goal or area of interest.	Sample development goal bank.
Own the action plan	Complete agreed actions and update progress.	Clear timeline and access to opportunities.
Ask for support	Identify what help, coaching, feedback, or resources are needed.	Manager guidance and psychological safety.
Review progress	Participate in follow-up conversations and adjust the plan as needed.	Scheduled checkpoints.